



Appendix C:

Business & Marketing

MATERIAL IN THIS SECTION IS WILL NOT BE TESTED ON

Understanding how to market your services is critical to your success as a running coach. The theory of *“If You Build It, They Will Come”* does not hold true in regard to becoming a successful coach. Your success as a coach will be directly correlated to how good a coach you are and how effectively you market yourself and your services.

Before you embark upon a marketing plan, you must know where you will focus on marketing your services. For example, an individual who is a coach at a health club will have a very different marketing strategy than someone who does not work at a health club.

The next thing to determine when deciding upon a marketing strategy is the budget. If you are a coach who is solely marketing your services “in-club,” there might not be any costs incurred with marketing your services. Additionally, there are many ways to “guerrilla” market yourself and your coaching business that require little to no money. This is especially the case when marketed via social networking sites. However, if you decide that you want to have a marketing budget, you will need to determine what type of marketing will give you the most bang for your buck.

Traditional marketing avenues for coaches that typically require some sort of fee are:

- Event exposition or sponsorship
- Magazine ads
- Internet banner ads
- Classified ads
- Mailing lists

❖ WEBSITE

Assuming you will be looking for clients outside of a health club environment, a website is a necessity. As most coaches do not have their own physical location, the website serves as the “store front” where prospective and existing clients can visit to learn about your services, credentials, and areas of focus.

The critical factor to remember with your website design is that the quality and professional appearance of the website is a direct reflection on you as a coach. Imagine what you would think if you walked by a storefront that was dilapidated and upon looking in the store, the lights were dim and the place was extremely dirty. Needless to say, your first impression would be quite bad. The same holds true for your website. It cannot be stressed enough that every aspect of your business needs to be professional—including the website. When determining what you want your website to look like, you should spend quite a bit of time looking at other coaching sites and also at sites outside of the coaching realm. Regardless of what site design you decide upon, it must be professional. This means the following things:

- Easy to navigate
- Clear and professional looking pictures and graphics
- No spelling errors
- All links/videos and buttons must be functional
- All information such as pricing and packages must be up to date
- If you have an online shopping cart it must be secure and fully functional
- The site must be up and working. No matter how great your site is, if the server is down or you have technical issues that prevent the site from being viewed live, this is a problem.

One very important aspect of a coaching website is testimonials. You will want to ask your clients with whom you have had the most success if they would be willing to write a short testimonial for you to put on your website. Ideally, some or all of the testimonials should be located on the homepage. The purpose of testimonials is to validate your effectiveness and professionalism as a coach.

As the website constitutes your storefront, you will get potential customers asking questions via email. You must answer these email inquiries within 24 hours—without exception and, ideally, within 12 hours or less. The longer it takes to

respond, the more it appears that you are not serious about your business or acquiring new clients.

In regard to website development, you should hire a professional who can design a great-looking and functional website for you. Not only is a professional website designer most likely going to do a better job than you, but they can also offer guidance on issues like online shopping carts, search engine optimization, and the overall structure of the site. Solely from a business and marketing standpoint, this is an area in which you will want to spend money, if you can. If you decide to try to create your own website, you have several primary options. The first way is to design it yourself using a “plug and play” site builder. These site builders typically offer templates into which you can enter your logo, pictures, videos, and written content.

The next method is to build a website from scratch. However, this takes a fair amount of expertise in areas such as website editors, HTML coding, and Photoshop®. One of the most popular website building/editing tool is Adobe Dreamweaver®. This is a professional website development tool and is considered by many to be the best website development/editing software.

Website developers usually have two primary pay structures. The first structure is a set price for a pre-determined number of website pages and additional charges for additional pages/features and re-designs. The other structure is based on an hourly fee. The most important thing from your end is to have a good idea of what you think you would like the site to look like and what features and functionality you would want the site to have—before contacting a developer. This will not only decrease the cost of the site, but will most likely make the end result exactly what you had in mind.

BUSINESS PLAN

Many people think that the only reason to write a business plan is to attract investors. This is incorrect. Writing a business plan is a necessity for anyone starting a business, no matter how large or small. The primary reason for writing a business plan is to create structure and to formalize your coaching process and ideas. The central part of a business plan is the mission statement. A mission statement represents the primary focus of your business and the reason why it is so important is because anything and everything you do within your business

should relate to the mission statement. A mission statement exists to ensure that you do not deviate from your original objective and focus.

A business plan typically has several areas. These areas are:

- Executive summary
- Business description
- Market analysis including competition, competitive analysis, and growth strategy
- Operations
- Management
- Financial components

While your business plan does not need to be long or involved, it should address most of the above areas. In regard to the financials, you probably will not need in-depth financial reporting, however you will need to keep track of the basics. For example, you will need to know your starting cash position in regard to your budget and your estimated income and expenditures. While the financials can be revisited and revised as your business develops, like the rest of the business plan, the financials serve as a road map to keep you on track financially.

For the purposes of this certification, the focus will be on the marketing aspect of the business plan.

MARKETING

While there are many ways to market your coaching business, it is advised to first look at low cost options before spending substantial amounts of money. For starters, many of these low cost marketing options are often just, if not more impactful than options that cost substantially more money.

The more marketing avenues you can utilize the better. The more ways a potential client hears and sees about your service, the greater the chance they will become a client.

ECONOMICAL MARKETING METHODS

Social Networking Sites

Some of the most popular sites that are great for marketing a coaching business are: Twitter®, Facebook®, LinkedIn®, YouTube®, Daily Mile®, and Instagram®.

Posting on Message Boards and Services Offered Sites

Message boards are a great way to demonstrate your expertise in regard to contributing to a conversation thread. Just be sure to read the board's terms of use, as many message boards do not allow solicitation or advertising.

Writing Articles for Magazines/Websites

This is a very effective way to get noticed as well as to advertise your expertise. Be sure that your website and email are included at the end of the article. Obviously, the more popular the magazine or website is, the more impact the article will have.

Presentations/Lectures to Groups

This is perhaps the most effective marketing avenue and is almost sure to result in serious inquiries. The great thing about lectures is that you are face-to-face with your potential clients. They can hear your expertise, experience your personality and most importantly, ask questions. Many triathlon, running, and cycling clubs have monthly or quarterly meetings. Additionally, many companies have a wellness component that puts on lectures from time to time about healthy living topics. All of these marketing avenues should be explored.

Newsletters

An important part of a website is a newsletter. This not only serves as a distribution list, but is also as a way to stay in contact with clients or potential clients. You want to be sure to make the newsletter relevant, which means something that is a quick read and very informative at the same time. The goal is to entice your newsletter subscribers to want to read the information rather than sending it directly to the trash.

Distribution List

A distribution (or contact) list is your database of clients, potential clients, and resources—essentially an electronic mailing list. The goal is to have as large a distribution list as possible. The more people are on the list, the better the chance that you will get a new client. Many common uses of a distribution lists are newsletters, emails, promotions, and general announcements. Be careful about what and how often you contact your distribution list as you do not want to come across as spam or irrelevant. It is also advised that within your distribution list, you create categories such as clients, potential clients, businesses, friends, etc.

Partnering with Ancillary Businesses

Relationships and partnerships with companies that offer services and products associated with running are invaluable. The value of cross marketing services, referrals, and promotions is immense. Remember, as a coach you are a single person and to get as much exposure to your potential audience, you need the help of other established individuals and organizations. The goal in partnerships is to create personal relationships with businesses. Therefore, once a solid relationship is established, it would be wise not to seek out other like businesses to partner with. For example, if you partner with a running store to put on events and cross promotions, you should not seek out other running stores to do the same thing, as it will likely devalue the relationship with the original running store. If you do plan to partner with competing stores in the same geographic area, you will need to let all of the businesses know your intentions up front.

A partnership is not a one-way street—both parties should benefit from the relationship. A quick way to sour a business partnership is only to focus on what you can get from the other side and not view it as a mutually beneficial relationship. Therefore, before approaching a business about a potential partnership, be ready to explain your ideas on how you feel the partnership can be beneficial to them.

Website Links

Having a section on your website that lists links to businesses with whom you partner is always a great way to advertise and provide additional resources to

your clients. Just make sure your business partners are doing the same for you. Typically, there is no fee incurred, as it is purely an exchange.

Networking

Networking is critical in the success of any business, but especially for one-person business. While networking needs to be done tastefully, you should always be attentive to how you can promote your business and services. While you can join professional networking groups, the most important step is to communicate as much as possible with as many people as possible. This is because successful networking is a numbers game. The more contacts you have, the greater the chance one of those contacts will turn into or refer a client to you. A great place to network is at endurance sport expos and events. You might have heard stories about how successful salespeople have gained clients while in the waiting room to see the dentist. You need to think and act along these lines. You need to view any situation as an opportunity to market yourself and your services tactfully.

Volunteer Work

Volunteering falls within the networking category. While volunteerism is important regardless of the reason for doing so, it also presents a marketing opportunity. This is especially true if the charity is endurance sports related. Some endurance sports-related volunteer work includes:

- Coaching charity based teams
- Volunteering at events
- Community-based exercise/fitness programs

Referrals from Existing Clients and Health Professionals

Your best referral source is your existing clients. If a client is happy with the services they have received, they will typically be more than willing to refer you to others. You can even create a referral program that offers incentives to existing clients that refer other clients (e.g., a free month of coaching).

It is important to establish a network of professionals (i.e., physician, chiropractor, physical therapist, nutritionist, etc.) that you can refer to. This type of relationship will bear fruit by becoming a two-way referral street. Additionally,

by advertising this professional network on your website, you will most likely be viewed as much more credible than one that does not have a network. A primary reason for this is because one's credibility is often authenticated by their associations. In addition, by having a network of referral sources, it shows that you take your coaching business seriously and understand that to obtain optimal results, you've adopted a team approach.

Blogging

Blogs have become a driving force in how companies and individuals market themselves. The primary value of blogs is that they are dynamic in nature versus most websites that are static. Due to this, online traffic and loyal readership are often quite high with blogs that put up new content on a regular basis. Many large and established corporations have identified the influence that bloggers have in regard to their loyal readership and thus look to partner with these blogs to promote their products and services.

It would be wise to consider either incorporating a blog on your website or making your website a blog. Regardless, the critical factor in having a successful blog is that it is updated frequently with fresh, relevant content.

Write an eBook

A great way to demonstrate your expertise is to write an eBook. Typically, eBooks that are used for marketing purposes are often offered for free or for a nominal fee. However, eBooks can also be used as a revenue source for your business. There are online shopping carts (e.g., www.e-junkie.com) that are made specifically for selling eBooks.

DETERMINING EFFECTIVENESS OF MARKETING

There are several ways to assess the effectiveness of a marketing strategy. Below are two of the more common and practical methods.

1. Conversion Rate:

This is represented by the number of people that sign up or purchase your service out of the total number of people that you marketed to (e.g., flyers mailed, number of people at seminar that you spoke at)

2. Cost to Acquire Client:

This is determined by taking the total amount spend on advertising and dividing that by the number of clients. This can be done for the business as a whole or based off of specific advertising campaigns. Obviously the lower the cost, the better.

Using these methods will greatly assist you in determining if your marketing strategy is profitable and to what degree.

DEVELOPMENT OF MARKETING PLAN

Successful marketing does not just happen, it requires planning. In order not to waste time, you need to ensure that your marketing strategies are effective and align with your budget. Development of a marketing plan can be broken up into four steps:

1. Determine Budget

Your marketing budget will determine to some degree what strategies will be implemented. In regard to strategies that will incur a cost, you should prioritize which ones are most important so that you are spending your money intelligently. This step takes time especially if you are hiring someone for the web design. You will want to make sure you are getting the right person or company for the job and at the best possible rate.

2. List and Categorize All Marketing Strategies

Write out all potential marketing strategies regardless of how minor they may seem.

3. Implementation Dates and Schedule for Strategies

Rank the strategies chronologically based on when they will be implemented. Then assign the strategies implementation dates as well as a schedule for each strategy (if the strategy is repeated). You will probably find that some strategies will be repeated at set intervals (e.g., newsletters) and others will be on-going (e.g., coaching one-on-one with company logo on clothing). It is also helpful to use the strategy list to approximate which strategies will require the most work and time to implement. For example, website design and development will require much more time than introducing yourself to the local running store manager.

4. Dates of Re-Assessment

Strategies are only useful if they work. Sometimes strategies do not deliver a *return on investment* (ROI) initially, but over the long run they bear fruit. Therefore, you want to give your strategies enough time to work before pulling the plug or re-tooling them. The best way to assess a strategy's effectiveness is simply to ask those that inquire about your services how they heard about you. You need to record this data so that you can assess what the most effective strategies are.

WHERE ARE YOUR CLIENTS?

How you market your services is largely dependent in what capacity will you be working with them. The following areas are the primary settings.

- Health Club
- Online
- Local/Regional

Health Club

If you currently work or plan to work in a health club environment, there are three key demographics to whom you will need to be able to demonstrate expertise. These areas are your fitness manager or director, fellow staff members, and, of course, the club members.

The reason why your fitness manager is so critical is because they are the ones that often get requests for personal trainers and coaches. If your manager knows that you are a running coach and able to train clients for all three-sport disciplines, you will be the first point of contact should someone ask for that type of coach.

Referrals in health clubs come from all areas including other personal trainers and coaches, membership advisors, and even front desk receptionists.

- **Personal Trainers/Coaches:** While on the surface, your fellow personal trainers and coaches might seem like competition for clients, which in some cases is true, it is up to you to distinguish yourself as a running

expert. One way to do this is to put on a running clinic for staff members. A clinic serves as a learning opportunity for the staff but also solidifies you as a running expert. This will increase the likelihood of getting referrals from colleagues. Keep in mind that referrals are a two-way street and you need to refer clients to fellow colleagues as well.

- **Membership Advisors:** They often sell not just memberships, but fitness packages as well. Most gyms offer some type of complimentary fitness session to new members and membership advisors will often inform the fitness director what the member's goals are. If the advisor already knows that you are a running coach and a member is training for a running race, they will most likely recommend you.
- **Front Desk Receptionists:** Receptionists are the first and last people that members see when they come in and leave. Because of this, many members have a great rapport with receptionists. Receptionists are the recipients of all sorts of questions including which fitness professional is the best with whom to work.

When marketing directly to members, there are several ways you can effectively market your expertise:

- Make sure your staff bio clearly states you are a certified running coach. If your facility does not have a staff bio board or some way to advertise the expertise of its staff, you need to push for this.
- Hold a free run coaching workshop for members and make sure it is marketed well.
 - People like free stuff. Partner with a local sports store for free give-a-ways to entice people to come to the workshop.
- Workout during busy times (if allowed) doing running-based exercises. This is a great way to get members attention and is often a conversation starter.
- Work with the group fitness director to teach a running-based group fitness class.

- If your health club offers specialized training packages, put together a running specific training package.
- Start a running club.
- Market your running success. Assuming you have or currently participate in running, work with your club to help market your participation and success. One way to do this is a raffle where members who guess closest to your race finishing time, wins a prize. This accomplishes two objectives: first, it gets members attention that you are a runner and second, it shows off that you are the real deal!

Online Coaching

In the age of technology and the internet, online coaching has really taken off. A key benefit to online coaching is that you can provide your coaching services from anywhere and to anyone. It is encouraged to do an internet search of endurance sports coaching companies to see how they organize their website, what rate(s) they charge, how the coaching structured, etc.

For many coaches, the biggest drawback to online coaching is that they do not have face-to-face contact with their client and are limited to phone and email correspondence. In regard to simply creating a weekly or monthly training program, this lack of face-to-face contact is not a large issue. The primary issue comes into play when you need to assess their biomechanical form and demonstrate strength training exercises. Using relatively inexpensive technology, your client can video their form and send you the file to review. Additionally, when demonstrating strength training form, the use of video conferencing such as Skype® is extremely useful. While there is no substitute for one-on-one coaching, technology makes it such that even without face-to-face contact, all aspects of coaching can be accomplished.

Local and Regional Coaching

If your primary target are local runners, the first question to ask yourself is based on your business plan projections: Are there are enough local athletes to sustain your business model? Regardless of the number of local athletes, it is also advisable to have an online coaching service, as this will only serve to increase your business. While networking is a critical element in a successful coaching, it

is especially the case when dealing primarily with local athletes. Of the aforementioned marketing areas, the ones most associated with marketing to local athletes are:

- Presentations/lectures to groups
- Partnerships with ancillary businesses
- Referrals from existing clients and health professionals
- Volunteer at events

MARKETING FOCAL POINTS

Market Success

When it comes to coaching, especially in sports like running where performance gains/losses are based on time, potential clients are looking for someone that can help them become faster and more efficient. In other words, when it comes to assessing performance, most runners are very quantitative in nature. This is where marketing your clients' successes come into play. While it is great to say that you have ten clients that have achieved *personal records* (PR) in marathon distance events, what is more valuable is how much time they took off from their previous marathon times. Getting the approval from and marketing your client's results is powerful and hard-hitting data that will entice others who want similar performance gains to work with you. The great thing about the sport of running is that data is available all over the place. Quantitative examples of gains made under your coaching supervision that could be mentioned are:

- Decreased run by 10 minutes
- No longer have lower back pain when running
- Decreased body fat percentage by 5% in one month
- Increased average pace 1 minute per mile

As noted previously, testimonials are very powerful as a marketing tool as they demonstrate positive experiences of your existing and past clients to potential clients. For the same reason why many people do not purchase products unless reading reviews, testimonials provide "reviews" of your ability and professionalism as a coach.

All Encompassing Resource

The more complete a resource you can be for your clients, the more valuable you will be to them. While you may not be a professional bike mechanic, if you can help your client fix their derailleur so that they do not have to take their bike into the shop, that is a huge value both in time and money. You can only be as much help as your scope of knowledge will allow you to be, but that is precisely the point. The broader your scope of knowledge is pertaining to the sport of running and all things that go along with it, the more invaluable you will be to your clients.

This also ties directly to having a professional network. Being able to refer your client to a registered dietitian, physical therapist, chiropractors, orthopedic physician, etc. demonstrates that you have a strong network of professionals that have gotten results for clients with similar goals.

Qualifications

Identify what makes you qualified to be a running coach and make this the center point of your marketing. If you are reading this, you obviously have chosen to become a certified running coach, which is the most specific qualification. While being a certified running coach is typically the number one thing that most potential clients will be looking for, there are other aspects that potential clients might look for as well. Some of these could be:

- Current or former runner
- Duration of coaching experience
- Degree in exercise physiology or related degree
- Personal trainer certification
- Athletic performance history
- Testimonials and/or references from past and current clients

❖ OPERATIONS

Over Deliver

If you say you are going to do something, do it exactly as promised and consistently. For example, if you tell a client you are going to call them at 5 p.m. to discuss their program, call them at 5 p.m., not at 5:03 or 5:05. While this sounds like common sense and not that big a deal, it is not common sense and it is a huge deal! Below are areas that often separate top coaches and personal trainers from those who are less successful:

- Punctual
- Consistent in the quality of the sessions
- Always have a positive attitude
- Go above and beyond what the client expected
- Return e-mails/calls in a timely manner
- Document thoroughly all workouts
- Pay attention to the details

Pricing

While on the surface, pricing seems like it should be pretty easy and simple to establish, rest assured that it is not. There are large volume books, MBAs, and psychology courses dedicated just to the subject of pricing. So, how does one decide what to charge? While you can charge whatever you think your services are worth, it is advised to perform due diligence by researching and benchmarking other coaching services. There are many factors in regard to pricing that you will need to consider. Some of these are:

- **Price of Local Market:** Coaching services in NYC would likely be higher than in a small rural town.
- **Volume:** Will you discount if a client purchases a large package of coaching or would you consider this “devaluing” your services?
- **Niche:** Are you trying to be a high-end specialty service or bargain basement “deal of the century” type of service? If you are looking to be either of these, your pricing should be substantially above and below the average coaching pricing, respectively.
- **Services:** You will have to look at what other coaching services offer for their prices. For example, if a competitor offers a weekly coaching program, analysis of heart rate and one coach-initiated phone call for \$350 per month, you will need to analyze what you offer in comparison and offer

a competitive price option. This is where you can stand apart. Let us say that you offer the same services as the example above, but in addition you also offer two calls a month, and a monthly strength/flexibility training program. You could charge \$350 to be a value-based service or charge more based on the extra services.

Cancellation Policy

Most fitness facilities have a cancellation policy and so should you. It is absolutely imperative that prior to starting with a new client, you express to them what the policy is as well as any exceptions to the policy. That said, it is encouraged that you create a cancellation policy with no exceptions. Of course things will come up (e.g., sickness, work related issues, transportation issues, no child care, etc.), however by adopting a policy with built-in exceptions, you are running a business model with a very slippery slope in regard to cancellations. Not all clients will intentionally take advantage of exceptions to cancel, but some will. Maybe your 6 a.m. client does not want to get out of bed in the morning and calls to cancel at the last minute saying they are sick. If you allow sickness as an exception to the policy, you will lose out on that session's revenue. The "no exception" policy sounds tough, but, in fact, it is the best insurance to acquire and maintain a steady and consistent client base.

When implementing this policy, you must be fair. If you have a "no exception" policy with a 12-hour cancellation policy, you **MUST** be held to the same standards. Meaning, if you are sick or your car breaks down and must cancel within 12 hours of a session, the client gets a complimentary session. Many fitness facilities have strict cancellation policies, however the policy is typically a one-way street in regard to the client. This is extremely frustrating to the client and can lead to dissatisfaction to the extent that a client stops training or being coached at that facility.

The last point about the cancellation policy is that it often serves the purpose to weed out "would be" habitual cancellation clients. While you are running a business and you need to generate revenue from the services you provide, you also are in the business of getting your clients the results they are seeking. By addressing the cancellation policy prior to starting to work with a client, you will often dissuade those that would cancel a lot from working with you. Do not view this as a negative that you lost a potential client, but rather as a positive that you are maintaining the integrity of your coaching business. In relation to the word of mouth section above, even if you retain clients that habitually cancel, these types

of clients typically do not refer other clients, as they are not seeing results themselves. It is a marketing dead end.

Run a Business—Not a Hobby

Whether or not you have one or one hundred clients, you need to view and operate your coaching practice as a business and not a hobby. This will be a critical element to your success as a running coach. Those that run their “business” as a hobby often fall short in most operational areas. For example, maybe coaching is a side business for an individual and as a result, they late cancel on their clients a lot due to their primary job responsibilities. This will hurt their coaching business. Another example is if the coach does not charge what would be considered the “fair market rate” for the particular area they are in or does not collect the coaching fees on time. Both of these examples lower the value of the coach and the perception of the coach from the client will likely be that of someone who is unprofessional and doing it as a “side” business.

Even if you coach on the side and have another primary job, it should not take a back seat to operational excellence. If you do not have the time or energy to coach “professionally “ on the side due to family or primary job responsibilities, it is better not to coach at all until you can commit to clients. Clients pay money for your services and should to be respected with your time, commitment, energy, and professionalism.

SUMMARY

- Your marketing strategy will differ greatly based on whether you are an independent coach or you work within an organization such as a health club.
- A professional website is important as this is your virtual “storefront.”
 - Right or wrong, the quality of your website often reflects upon the quality of your services.
- Development of a business plan is not just for acquiring investors or capital. A business plan helps to identify your goals, direction, marketing, and the overall trajectory of your business.
- Economical marketing strategies offer a cost-effective and impactful way to attract potential clients.

- Social media is at the forefront of economical marketing that has the potential to be highly impactful.
- If marketing within a health club environment, personal trainers, front desk staff and membership advisors are often great sources of referrals.
- By tracking the conversion rate and the cost to acquire a client, you can determine the effectiveness of a marketing strategy.
- Perform extensive due diligence when determining how to price your services.
- The cancellation policy must be a two-way street.
- If you charge money for your services, it is a job—not a hobby. The business operations must reflect a high level of professionalism.